

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 228

By Faison

A RESOLUTION to recognize and honor legendary bassist Victor Wooten.

WHEREAS, it is the privilege of the members of this General Assembly to honor those citizens whose devotion to craft and artistic integrity not only result in exceptional art but also inspire people throughout this State and around the world; and

WHEREAS, one such individual is Victor Lemonte Wooten, a skilled naturalist, teacher, magician, acrobat, husband, father of four, songwriter, record producer, and one of the most esteemed bass players in the history of the instrument; and

WHEREAS, although he now calls Nashville home, Mr. Wooten was born just outside of Boise, Idaho, on September 11, 1964, and spent his formative years in Hawaii, where his parents, Dorothy and Elijah Wooten, were stationed as members of the United States Air Force; and

WHEREAS, he was "born into a band," with brothers Regi on guitar, Roy on drums, Rudy on saxophone, and Joseph on keys, all of them happy to welcome the arrival of their baby brother/new bassist to round out the quintet; he has had an instrument in his hands since the age of two and states that he acquired music as one does a language, through unfettered access and the freedom to experiment; and

WHEREAS, The Wooten Brothers Band hit the road when Victor was only six years old, opening for the iconic Curtis Mayfield; soon after, he was affectionately known as the eight-year-old Bass Ace, and before graduating from high school in Newport News, Virginia, he shared the stage with artists such as Stephanie Mills, War, Ramsey Lewis, Frankie Beverly and Maze, Dexter Wansel, and The Temptations; and

WHEREAS, now a five-time Grammy Award winner, Mr. Wooten hit the worldwide scene in 1990 as a founding member of the eclectic supergroup Béla Fleck and the Flecktones, along with banjo player Béla Fleck, Victor's brother Roy "Future Man" Wooten, and harmonica and piano wizard Howard Levy; the band created a completely new sound and has become known for its genre-defying music. It is still going strong to this day; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Wooten's sought-after skills and growing popularity led to his recording and performing with artists such as Tommy Emmanuel, Chick Corea, The Dave Matthews Band, Bootsy Collins, Branford Marsalis, Mike Stern, Prince, India Arie, Keb Mo, Dennis Chambers, Susan Tedeschi, Gov't Mule, Bruce Hornsby, Stanley Clarke, Marcus Miller, Frank Gambale, and the legendary Moroccan group Nass El Ghiwane, among many others; and

WHEREAS, in 1996, Victor Wooten's first solo project, *A Show of Hands*, was recorded with only a four-string bass, no multitracking, and a lot of groove and soul; this revolutionary album has been hailed as one of the most important bass records of all time; and

WHEREAS, devoted to giving back to youth and fostering a love of music in upcoming generations, Mr. Wooten created a music program in 2000 called "Bass/Nature camp," which was expanded to include all instruments under the moniker "Victor Wooten's Center for Music and Nature"; his camps found a permanent home in 2009 at Wooten Woods, a nearly 150-acre retreat located on Duck River west of Nashville owned by Victor and his wife, Holly; and

WHEREAS, he has also been in service to others through teaching at Berklee College of Music in Boston, Massachusetts, co-leading the Victor Wooten/Berklee Summer Bass Workshop; at Berklee, as at his own camps, he collaborates with Berklee Bass Department Chair Steve Bailey, alongside whom he has been teaching since the early 1990s; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Wooten has penned two books—*The Music Lesson: A Spiritual Search for Growth Through Music* and *The Spirit of Music: The Lesson Continues*, and he owns Vix Records, which releases his albums; and

WHEREAS, in addition to his Grammy honors, Victor Wooten has been named Bass Player of the Year by *Bass Player Magazine* on three occasions and is the first person to win that prestigious award more than once; in 2011, he was ranked No. 10 in the Top 10 Bassists of All Time by readers of *Rolling Stone* magazine; and

WHEREAS, taking to heart his mother's words, "The world needs more than just good musicians. We need good people," Victor Wooten did not content himself with being one of the most celebrated musicians of all time—he has continued to be an example of the sort of person the world needs, one who embodies compassion, humility, and service above self; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we recognize and honor Victor Wooten for his many contributions to the State of Tennessee through his artistry and generosity of spirit, extending our best wishes for every continued success.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.